To what extent are consumers shifting from established luxury labels to emerging fashion brands, and what factors (price sensitivity, sustainability concerns, digital influence, or identity expression) are driving this transition?

Research Paper By Sagan Aggarwal

Abstract

Recent studies show that younger generation of consumers have more willingness and tend to try new brands instead of old luxury brand that their parents used. More than brand and status they care about other factors such as ethics, transparency, and self-expression. This is very common pattern observed in recent years especially in Millennials and Gen Z. In this era of social media relatively smaller and local brands have reached to global consumers and the prices of luxury items have increased by multifold. This paper studies how much consumers are moving away from bigger and well-established luxury brands toward emerging fashion brands that are relatively new, and why this change is happening. The main research question is: ***To what extent are consumers shifting from established luxury houses and why is this shift taking place?, are the main reasons price sensitivity, sustainability concerns, digital influence, or identity expression causing the change****?* This study used secondary data from industry reports, market surveys, and academic research, along with data existing consumer questionnaires available in public domain and case studies from fashion market. Clear comparison of traditional luxury labels and emerging brands on four key factors: price, sustainability, digital channels, and personal identity. The research work also gives sincere attention to how brands respects or issue the cultural symbols and designs to show cultural stativity and cultural risk. The findings show there is a shift of consumer behaviors, they are not running behind the luxury brands they are very active in experimenting with the emerging brands that suits their budget, value and lifestyle. Among the urban youth sustainability, It is observed that other than price sensitivity, influence of digital media ,are desire to look unique, sustainability and identity expression are especially important drivers of this shift.

Keywords: Luxury fashion, emerging brands, consumer behavior, sustainability, digital influence, identity expression, price sensitivity

Introduction

Luxury fashion industry underwent through major changes especially in the post COVID-19 pandemic era. The prices of luxury brand have increased, and sales of luxury goods and fashion market are at all time high this shows that market for luxury items are growing but recent report suggest that year on year growth rate is slowing and becoming uneven and customer groups. According to Bain & Company's 2023 Luxury Report, the global luxury market reached €1.5 trillion, showing strong growth, but the report also notes that younger consumers are willing to experiment and more selective about which brands they support[1]. Repeated price hikes in big and luxury brands made them careful about what they are buying and from whom. At the same time, emerging and independent fashion brands have become more visible and influential as they offer fresh design and more flexible pricing. moreover, these smaller brands offering lower prices, stronger sustainability promises, innovative digital marketing, and designs that match personal identity or niche communities. Modern consumers are attracted to such combinations who want something different from traditional, status-focused luxury labels.

Another major change comes from the habits of Gen Z and Millennials, who now make up more than 70% of luxury spending growth[2].These younger consumers look for brands that feel authentic, honest socially responsible, transparent, closer to their daily lives and aligned with their personal values instead of chasing prestige logos. Studies show that more than 60% of Gen Z shoppers prefer brands that reflect their identity, and over 50% look

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[1] (Bain & Company. (2023, November 14). *Global luxury market projected to reach €1.5 trillion in 2023, a new record for the sector, as consumers seek luxury experiences*. https://www.bain.com/about/media-center/press-releases/2023/global-luxury-market-projected-to-reach-1.5-trillion-in-2023-a-new-record-for-the-sector-as-consumers-seek-luxury-experiences)

[2] (McKinsey & Company. (2023). *The State of Fashion 2023*. https://www.mckinsey.com/industries/retail/our-insights/state-of-fashion).

for sustainable efforts or **ethical production with clear ethical standards**[3].These values show that new generation buyers are more willing than previous generation to create a strong demand for new fashion labels that offer originality, ethical production, and community-driven branding. Social media platforms like TikTok ,Instagram and other emerging social media apps have also helped these small and mid-size brands trend and grow quickly by making fashion trends spread faster. Relying on digital-first strategies, using social media, online drops, and direct-to-consumer platforms instead of traditional runway shows or glossy print campaigns. This approach allows them to build close communities around the brand, collect quick feedback, and adjust styles to what their audience actually wants. For example, brands such as Telfar, House of Sunny, and Jacquemus feel more personal and strengthens emotionally connected and reached global audience mainly due to online campaigns and social media advertisement where normal people post their reviews about new instead of traditional luxury advertising. As a result, consumers have more options and choice and are no longer limited to long-established luxury houses like Louis Vuitton, Gucci, or Chanel. However, this transformation in taste and behavior also creates important challenges for luxury brands. Many luxury labels have increased their prices citing inflation and increased cost of production sharply in the last five years, which makes them less accessible, especially for young buyers. Moreover emerging brands offer easy and stylish alternatives at much lower prices. This leads to a key question in today’s fashion industry- Are consumers now moving away from established luxury brands and choosing emerging brands instead? Multiple survey and studies suggest that this sift s happening , but in depth study id required to understand the true extent and the reasons behind it. Continuous decline in the and slowdown in the customer loyalty for Traditional luxury brands, especially among younger

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[3] (Deloitte. (2023). *The Gen Z and Millennial survey*. https://www2.deloitte.com/global/en/pages/about-deloitte/articles/genzmillennialsurvey.html).

consumers. While luxury fashion is still popular, buyers are no longer committed to just a few well-known labels. Instead, they are experimenting and trying a wide variety of new and emerging brands that better meet their expectations for affordability, uses recyclable and greener material, digital engagement, and identity expression. Luxury houses now face competition not only from other luxury brands but also from independent designers, street wear labels, and digital-first fashion companies. This changing behavior shows a need to understand why consumers are moving away and what factors are shaping these choices. Even though many reports discuss luxury fashion trends, there is limited research that directly compares *why* consumers are shifting from established luxury brands to new or emerging labels. Most academic research focus on luxury marketing strategies, brand loyalty, or consumer identity in isolation. Only limited number of studies explore how price sensitivity, sustainability concerns, cultural sensitivity, risk, digital influence, and identity expression all work together to drive this shift. Cultural sensitivity here means how these brands treat cultural ethnic and religious symbols , believes symbols and practices. Also it has been noticed that many young consumers prioritise belongingness more than exclusivity and not how expensive the brand is, they like that brands that feels more close to their culture and values. The exact cause behind the transition remain unclear due to this gap in studies. Thus, main purpose study aims to bring together these different factors and examine them in a single framework to understand what motivates consumers today. The purpose of the research is to understand both the scale of this movement and the reasons behind this transition, especially among younger consumers. The present study addresses this gap by asking: To what extent are consumers moving away from established luxury labels to emerging fashion brands, and which of the four factors price, sustainability, digital influence, identity expression and cultural sensitivity are most important in this transition? The research focuses on younger consumers, who are reshaping the fashion market, and aims to build an integrated view of how economic, social, and cultural divers working together and changing the luxury consumption today.

Literature Review

Luxury fashion symbolizes of wealth, power, and social status. Consumer research on luxury brand and emerging brans shows that there is a clear shift in buying behaviors. Early work and most famous explanations of luxury is by Thorstein Veblen (1899), who described luxury as **"conspicuous consumption"** meaning how rich people buy expensive goods to show their status in society rather than practical use of it . Later many writers explain that, for Veblen, luxury is not only about function but about showing off money and class position[4].Pierre Bourdieu (1984) adds another important idea with his theory of **"distinction"**. He argued that individuals use their taste, style, and culture to separate social classes. Luxury goods are one way to signal "cultural capital," such as refined taste, knowledge of brands, and aesthetic judgment[5]. Luxury has become more broad and personal people not only priorities visibility ,symbols , recognition , logos instead they attach more emotional values , stories and experiences to the luxury products. These theories show that consumption of luxury brands a tool to communicate social position more than the quality and utility of the products. Recent work on contemporary luxury shows that consumers still care about symbolism and cultural meanings, but also look for experiences, stories, and

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[4] Bernheim, B. D., & Hodrick, L. (1996). Veblen effects in a theory of conspicuous consumption. *American Economic Review, 86*(3), 349–373. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/4980724_Veblen_Effects_in_a_Theory_of_Conspicuous_Consumption

[5] Trigg, A. B. (2000). *Veblen, Bourdieu and conspicuous consumption* (Discussion Paper No. 17). Open University. https://oro.open.ac.uk/89777/1/17F.pdf

emotional value, not just logos [6].Industry reports show that the luxury market is still very large remains strong in terms of profit , but the pattern of consumption is changing growth is unevern especially because of younger generation. Bain & Company notes that personal luxury goods continue to grow, but Genz buyers are less loyal to single brands[7]. McKinsey's *State of Fashion* reports show that luxury produces a large share of the industry's profit, yet faces pressure from slower growth, higher prices, and changing consumer expectations. Reuters also reports that Generation Z, who will form a growing share of luxury spending by 2030, they prefer to create individual style by mixing luxury with secondhand, streetwear, and niche labels rather than only buying fixed old labels [8]. These trends suggest that the meaning of luxury is moving from fixed, old labels toward more flexible, personal ideas of value when authenticity and relevance matters as much as heritage .In the span of last 8-10 years, many writers and industry analysts have described the rise of **"new luxury"** and independent fashion brands. Highsnobiety's *New Luxury* work explains that luxury today is strongly driven by youth culture, streetwear, fast moving collaboration, and digital media hype , and that small, agile brands can gain status very quickly if they connect with culture and community.[9] This "new luxury" is less about long heritage and more about creativity, story telling , and cultural relevance.

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[6] (Wang, Y. (2022). A conceptual framework of contemporary luxury consumption. *Journal of Business Research*.https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0167811621000914).

[7] (Bain & Company. (2023, November 14). *Global luxury market projected to reach €1.5 trillion in 2023, a new record for the sector, as consumers seek luxury experiences*. https://www.bain.com/about/media-center/press-releases/2023/global-luxury-market-projected-to-reach-1.5-trillion-in-2023-a-new-record-for-the-sector-as-consumers-seek-luxury-experiences)

[8] (McKinsey & Company. (2023). *The State of Fashion 2023*. https://www.mckinsey.com/industries/retail/our-insights/state-of-fashion).

[9] (Highsnobiety. (2024). *New luxury: New rules* [PDF]. Scribd. https://www.scribd.com/document/756517286/HIGHSNOBIETY-New-Luxury-New-Rules-2024)

A case in reference: Gucci sikh style turban

Another key part of new generation fashion is cultural sensitivity. Some brands have very strong backlash for using the religious and cultural symbols in careless manner ,for instance when Gucci launched its Sikh-style turban . Some of the Sikh consumers felt their religious sentiments are being hurt as their religious identity was turned to a costume the brand lost the trust and loyalty of many of its consumers as it ignored the cultural meaning of the religious symbol, these incidents show that cultural risk is real. Contrary to these , gen-z and new generation buyers try to associate them to those brands that show respect for cultural memory, local traditions, and community.

The Gucci Sikh Turban controversy functions as an ideal negative case study which proves how consumers now choose new luxury brands instead of traditional ones. The controversy demonstrates why consumers now prefer emerging brands over established luxury labels because of Identity Expression and Digital Influence. The research question connects to this particular incident through the following evidence: The research question investigates how Identity Expression acts as a driving force for consumers to choose new brands. The Gucci incident demonstrates how brands lose customer loyalty when they disregard identity-based values. The Incident: Gucci introduced the "Indy Full Turban" at a price of ~$790. People in today's world choose brands to show their personal identity. Consumers need to leave established brands like Gucci when these brands use sacred identity symbols as fashion items because it damages their personal identity. Consumers choose to support new brands which understand cultural nuances instead of focusing on visual appeal.

The research question investigates how digital influence operates in the market. Digital platforms serve as the ultimate authority which determines how brands should behave according to the Gucci incident. The controversy spread through Twitter (now X) when it first emerged in the online space. Digital influence has evolved from influencer product promotion into community-based brand value enforcement. Digital pressure accelerates the process of legacy brands moving toward more sensitive corporate practices.

The pre-wrapped turban from Gucci came with an $800 price tag. The daily practice of tying turbans by Sikhs requires inexpensive cloth materials. The Link demonstrates how established brands face a "Value Crisis" in their market. Consumers want to know why they must pay 1000% more for brands that fail to grasp their products' true value. The price difference between authentic emerging brands and established brands drives customers toward new labels that deliver both authenticity and skilled craftsmanship at affordable rates.

Contrary to these, gen z and new generation buyers try to associate them to those brands that show respect for cultural memory, local traditions, and community.

Brands like **Jacquemus** and **Telfar** can be used as key examples to explain this shift in luxury consumption . both the brans are relatively small compared to traditional brands and is still independent but has grown very fast, with revenues close to €300 million by 2023. This fast rate of growth is because of using playful and image drive social media campaign and strong artistic direction .Analysts note that Jacquemus uses Instagram and storytelling , emotional content to “democratize” luxury and make it feel more accessible and human.[10]Telfar is another key case. It calls itself “not for you — for everyone” and offers bags that are much cheaper than traditional luxury handbags, but with strong cultural meaning community appeal. That attracts those group of people who have been excluded

[10] (Ewha Brand Communication. (2020, April 20). *Adapting the luxury industry to the era of digitalization: Jacquemus — A success story*. https://ewhabrandcommunication.wordpress.com/2020/04/20/adapting-the-luxury-industry-to-this-era-of-digitalization-jacquemus-a-success-story/)

from traditional luxury spaces for long[11] The "Bushwick Birkin" became a symbol of accessible luxury, especially for communities often excluded from traditional luxury [12]. This shows that new and emerging brands can coopete with established brands by offering new stories, fairer prices, and identity-based communities , that is also confirmed by the news Industry data. Highsnobiety and other experts suggest that show that "new luxury" brands led by innovative and creative founders are "growing at light speed"[13].The Vogue Business Index recently published that Jacquemus and Ami Paris as new entrants, recognizing their strong digital presence and cultural influence.[14] This literature suggests that the real power of fashion system is carried by the emerging brands they are not just niche player.

High inflation, increasing housing costs, and economic uncertainty make consumers have less disposable income as a result consumers become more careful with money. In addition to abovementioned factors Researchers found that price sensitivity, and cultural sensitivity are one of the strongest reasons that can be linked to the rise of new luxury brands. EY's *Future Consumer Index* shows that affordability has become a top priority in many markets, with consumers "learning to live with less" and often prefer to go with cheaper brands or private labels[15]. For instance example, an EY report notes that 52% of Indian

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[11] (Desiree Design. (2024, October 1). *How Telfar became the symbol of accessible luxury*. https://www.desireedesign.co.uk/brand-insider/telfar-luxury-branding-case-study)

[12] (Vogue. (2020, July 29). *Telfar built an accessible luxury brand. Then the bots came*. https://www.vogue.com/article/telfar-built-an-accessible-luxury-brand-then-the-bots-came)

[13] Stagg, N. (2025). *Luxury redefined: Stop selling the dream. Start fitting into reality* [White paper]. Highsnobiety. https://www.highsnobiety.com/p/luxury-redefined-white-paper-2025/)

[14] (Vogue Business. (2025, March). *Traditional digital marketing is going amiss. Should luxury go lo-fi?* https://www.vogue.com/article/traditional-digital-marketing-is-going-amiss-should-luxury-go-lo-fi)

[15] (EY. (2024, July 23). *Consumers return to physical stores for personal service even as AI and tech revolutionize online shopping*. https://www.ey.com/en_gl/newsroom/2023/11/ey-future-consumer-index-consumers-learning-to-live-with-less-as-climate-change-and-cost-of-living-reality-hits-home)

consumers are moving to private-label brands and many believe these offer better value than traditional expensive brands[16].Deloitte and other consultancies describe a “smart spend” mindset, where people still want style and self-expression but look for better price–value balance, especially in non-essential categories like fashion[17]. Reuters reports that Gen Z luxury buyers often buy fewer full-price luxury items and instead mix them with affordable “dupes,” secondhand pieces, or more accessible brands.[18] Academic studies on luxury demand also show that luxury goods can be **price elastic** for many consumers: sharp price increases can push them to alternatives, even if they still like the brand image.[19] . in this way the literature suggest that younger consumers choose style and fashion and luxury that is more affordable and sustainable that is offered by the new and emerging brands , economic pressure and constantly increase in prices of established luxury brands are the main driving force. High environmental cost, including pollution, water use, carbon emissions, and labor issues can be liked to fashion industry studies show that people and individual consumer are well awae about the negative impact or rising fashing industry and they are running social media campaigns to increase awareness about produces that are more eco friendly and protect human rights. The Geneva Environment Network reports to reduce the adverse impact of

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16 (The Economic Times. (2025, February 23). *52% consumers are switching to private labels: EY report*. https://economictimes.indiatimes.com/industry/services/retail/52-consumers-are-switching-to-private-labels-ey-report/articleshow/121311397.cms)

17 (Kadence International. (2024). How the smart spend mindset is reshaping the luxury market. https://kadence.com/en-us/knowledge/how-the-smart-spend-mindset-is-reshaping-the-luxury-market/)

18 (Marshak, S. (2025, September 19). *Luxury brands' big challenge: Figuring out Gen Z*. Reuters. https://www.reuters.com/business/retail-consumer/luxury-brands-big-challenge-figuring-out-gen-z-2025-09-19/

19 (Kastanakis, M. N. (2010). *Explaining variation in luxury consumption* (Unpublished doctoral thesis). City University London. https://openaccess.city.ac.uk/id/eprint/8695/1/Explaning_variation_in_luxury_consumption.pdf)

fashion on environment and human rights we need to shift to alternatives that are more.[20] McKinsey's work on sustainable fashion finds that many European consumers changed their fashion buying habits to reduce environmental impact, and they expect brands to use better materials and more transparent supply chains. [21] EY's *Future Consumer Index* also found that climate change is pushing consumers to rethink how and what they buy, though sustainable products are more expensive sometimes but some segments that can afford it is still actively choosing these options.[22]

However, there is mistrust in the market as there are few big brand that green wash their customers and they claim their products are sustainable as their climes are not clear and not supported by evidence. This opens space for smaller brands that build their identity around clear ethical values, such as upcycling, local production, fair wages, or vegan materials. Emerging labels like Pangaia and many small designers use sustainability as a central part of their brand story, appealing to Gen Z and Millennial consumers who want their clothes to reflect their ethical beliefs[23]. Digital media plays a huge role in how people discover and choose fashion brands. Studies show that platforms like Instagram and TikTok allow trends to spread very quickly and give power to **influencers**, **micro-influencers**, and even ordinary users. Fibre2Fashion notes that TikTok is driven by micro-influencers and everyday creators, and that its short video format helps create fast "micro-trends" that can lift

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[20] Geneva Environment Network. (2025, October 3). *Sustainable fashion*. https://www.genevaenvironmentnetwork.org/resources/updates/sustainable-fashion)

[21] McKinsey & Company. (2020). The future of fashion: Sustainable brands and "circular" business models. https://www.mckinsey.com/featured-insights/the-next-normal/fashion)

[22] EY. (2023, November 9). *EY Future Consumer Index: Consumers learning to live with less as climate change and cost-of-living reality hits home*. https://www.ey.com/en_om/future-consumer-index)

[23] (McKinsey & Company. (2023). *The State of Fashion 2023*. https://www.mckinsey.com/industries/retail/our-insights/state-of-fashion.

small brands almost overnight[24]. Guides on social media in fashion describe how digital spaces create communities, niche aesthetics, and style “tribes” that encourage experimentation and support for emerging labels.[25]

Many fashion reports state that a large share of consumers now discover brands through social media; one Vogue Business analysis reports that around 40% of luxury customers first encounter brands online.[26] Jacquemus is often cited as a model of digital-native luxury: it uses playful, highly visual content and behind-the-scenes posts to build emotional connection, leading to strong growth and high digital engagement [27]

Influencer lists and campaign reviews also show that collaborations between influencers and both luxury and emerging brands are now central to shaping trends and driving sales[28].) This literature suggests that digital influence lowers entry barriers for new brands and makes it easier for consumers to notice and try alternatives to established luxury labels.

Finally, many authors agree that fashion is a key tool for **identity expression**. Bourdieu’s work shows that taste and style are linked to social position, but newer writing on

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[24] (Shah, D. (2024). The impact of social media on fashion trends: Instagram vs. TikTok. Kadence International. https://kadence.com/en-us/knowledge/how-the-smart-spend-mindset-is-reshaping-the-luxury-market/)

[25] (Uphance. (2024). *The ultimate guide to social media in fashion*. https://www.uphance.com/insights/guide-to-social-media-in-fashion)

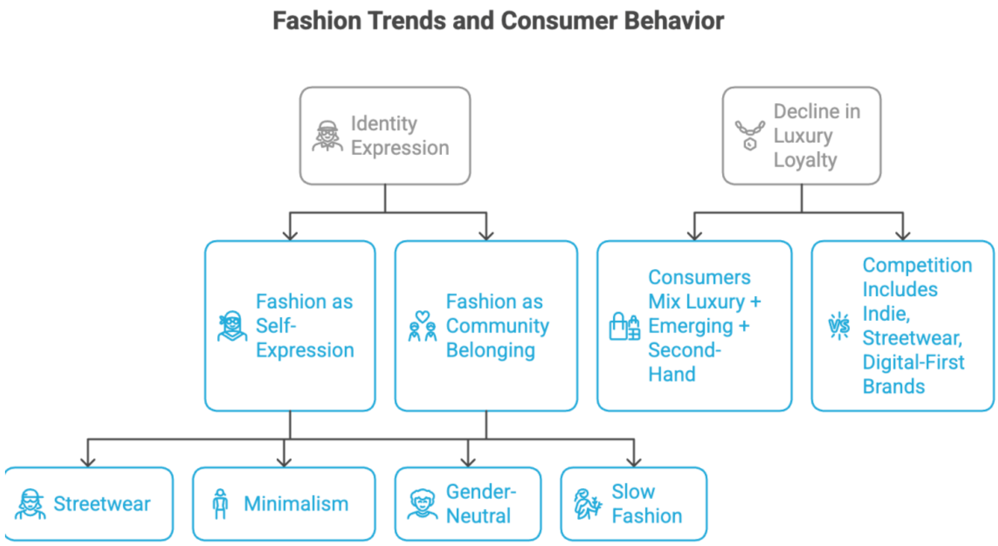
[26] (Vogue Business. (2025, March). *Traditional digital marketing is going amiss. Should luxury go lo-fi?* https://www.vogue.com/article/traditional-digital-marketing-is-going-amiss-should-luxury-go-lo-fi)

[27] (Business of Fashion. (2022, October 5). *Jacquemus: A fashion star’s business vision*. https://www.businessoffashion.com/articles/luxury/jacquemus-a-fashion-stars-business-vision)

[28] (JD Institute of Fashion Technology. (n.d.). *How digital influencers shape fashion brands and trends*. https://www.jdinstitute.edu.in/how-digital-influencers-shape-fashion-brands-and-trends/

"new luxury" suggests that today's consumers also use brands to express values, subcultures, and personal stories [29]Telfar's slogan "not for you — for everyone" is often highlighted as an example of a brand that builds identity around inclusion and community rather than exclusivity . [30]Emerging fashion labels often serve specific identities—such as gender-fluid fashion, streetwear communities, or local cultural styles—and this makes them attractive to consumers who feel unseen or underrepresented by traditional luxury houses.

Figure -1 Fashion Trends and Consumer Behavior



Methodology

This research is based completely on **secondary data**, meaning all information comes from existing reports, published research, expert opinions, and trustworthy online sources. No

[29] (Wang, Y. (2022). A conceptual framework of contemporary luxury consumption. *Journal of Business Research*.https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0167811621000914).

[30] Desiree Design. (2024, October 1). How Telfar became the symbol of accessible luxury. https://www.desireedesign.co.uk/brand-insider/telfar-luxury-branding-case-study)

primary data such as surveys or interviews were collected. This approach is suitable because the topic focuses on global consumer trends, habits of GenZ and millennial consumers, fashion industry patterns, and market insights that are already well-documented by large consulting firm and research agencies and academic studies. These organisations have access to big datasets and advanced methods that would be difficult and costly for a single researcher to reproduce, so drawing on their work is a practical and efficient way to understand broad market patterns the study uses a **qualitative and descriptive research design** based only on secondary sources. This method is suitable for this study because it allows the r to analyse trends, compare findings from different reports, and understand how consumer behaviour is changing over time. Secondary research is effective for large topics like luxury fashion, where many respected organizations such as McKinsey, Bain & Company, Deloitte, and Statista have already gathered extensive data. Using these existing sources also helps build a strong understanding of the factors influencing the shift from luxury labels to emerging brands. This design focuses on identifying patterns, themes, and expert insights rather than collecting new data. The key area included price sensitivity, concerns related to sustainability, digital influence Identity expressions and cultural belongingness where study of cultural sensitivity and belongingness mainly discusses the respecting or misuse if religious dress ,traditions and symbols

All data in this research come from **secondary sources**, including industry reports, fashion market studies, academic papers, and expert commentary. The most important sources are Deloitte’s Global Powers of Luxury Goods, that provides information about the performance of major luxury brands and global market structures in the recent year.

1. McKinsey’s State of Fashion 2023–2025 reports, that is used to undestad and explant consumer trends, fashion, generational shifts, the impact of digital influence, and sustainability attitudes, in the consumers choice.
2. Bain & Company’s luxury market report, is used to explain that the global luxury market reached €1.5 trillion in 2023 and to understand the expectionas of global consumers.
3. Statista, which offers numerical data and quantitative data about size of market , spending habits, brand preference, and generational buying behaviour. Additional expert insights from Highsnobiety, Vogue Business, BrandsGateway, and academic journals.

These sources are more reliable and provide up to date data and based on lager sample size of survey that’s why it is suitable to use it for business and academic research. Using multiple sources also allows cross-checking of information to ensure accuracy. Because this study relies only on secondary data, no participants or direct survey was done. Instead, the research focuses on data collected by major organizations that already study different consumer groups, especially Gen Z and Millennials. These age groups are important because multiple reports show they are the cause behind most of the change in fashion spending and are more open to buying from emerging brands. For example, McKinsey and Bain provide breakdowns of generational behaviour and pattern, while Statista offers age-based consumer patterns. Therefore, instead of collecting new responses, this research uses the demographic information already provided in these existing reports. The study uses thematic analysis to examine secondary data. This means the researcher reads all reports, articles, and studies carefully and identifies repeated themes related to the research question. The main themes include price sensitivity, sustainability concerns, digital influence, and identity expression.

Each theme is analysed by comparing information from multiple sources to see where experts agree or differ. For example, if several reports say Gen Z prefers sustainable brands, that becomes a strong theme. If different articles show that social media strongly affects brand discovery, that becomes another key theme. Charts and statistical findings from secondary sources (such as Statista graphs or McKinsey tables) are interpreted to understand overall trends, but no new statistical calculations are done by the researcher. This method helps create a clear and complete understanding of the shift from luxury to emerging brands.

Limitations

This study has some limitations because it depends only on secondary data. First, the research relies on information collected by other organizations, so it is limited by what those reports choose to measure. Secondly there are sone sources whose study is mainly focused on specific geography regional scale and extent (such as Europe or North America), thus it might not show the general pattern and trend of the global consumer . Third, the method of research , data collection compilation and analysis varies in these secondary reports that making direct comparison was difficult. Finally, since the study does not include primary surveys, expert interviews, it cannot capture personal views from individual consumers. These limitations are acknowledged and considered when interpreting the results.

Data Analysis & Findings

Recent data suggest a noticeable generational shift in fashion consumption. The global personal luxury goods market remains strong: one study estimates the broader luxury goods market grew from about US$226.61 billion in 2013 to around US$346.19 billion in

2023 showing a rising demand over time. [31]However, the way younger consumers especially Generation Z and younger Millennials approach luxury is changing. According to a 2025 industry report, many Gen Z and Millennials are expected to account for a large share of future luxury spending, but their tastes are less predictable and more value-driven than previous generations. Additional analyses reveal that these younger consumers are more open to mixing and matching: rather than buying only established luxury, they often combine high-end items with emerging brand items or more affordable fashion. [32] Meanwhile, the growth of second-hand fashion and resale markets also hints at deeper shifts: rising resale activity suggests that people are not necessarily loyal to a single brand but are comfortable trading, reselling, and re-buying behaviour more aligned with flexible consumption than traditional luxury loyalty[33]. Overall, though not all luxury buyers have abandoned established brands, a clear portion of younger consumers are diversifying their fashion purchases increasingly including emerging, indie or second-hand labels alongside or instead of classic luxury houses. This suggests the shift is real and growing, especially among younger, more value- and identity-conscious buyers.

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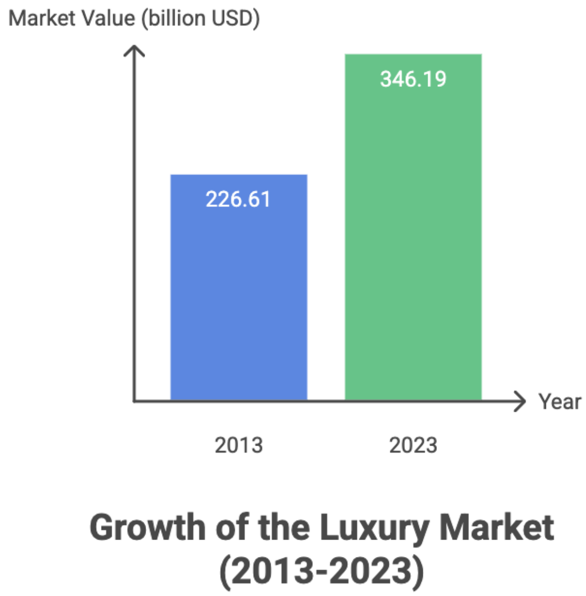
[31] Chernov, S., & Gura, D. (2024). The luxury goods market: Understanding the psychology of Chinese consumers. *International Journal of Industrial Engineering and Management, 100,* 100254. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.iedeen.2024.100254

[32] Andreeva, S. (2024, December 5). How Gen Z purchasing behavior is shaping clothing retail? BrandsGateway. https://brandsgateway.com/blog/gen-z-purchasing-behavior/)

[33] (Global Market Insights. (2025, April). Second-hand fashion market: By product type, by price range, by consumer group, by distribution channel & global forecast, 2025–2034 (Report ID: GMI9640). https://www.gminsights.com/industry-analysis/second-hand-fashion-market)

Figure 2- Luxury Market Growth (2013–2023)



One strong driver identified across recent studies is price sensitivity — especially among younger shoppers. Economic pressures like inflation, rising living costs, and uncertainty have made many consumers more cautious about spending. A 2024 report by PwC found that many consumers are still willing to spend more on sustainably produced items, but even then, they only pay a modest premium (on average about 9.7% more) for sustainability, rather than large luxury markups.[34] Moreover, a recent study on fashion consumption patterns found that **price, public awareness (e.g. sustainability), and social media** significantly affect purchase behavior — with social media being the strongest

[34] PwC. (2024, May 15). Consumers willing to pay 9.7% sustainability premium, even as cost-of-living and inflationary concerns weigh: PwC 2024 Voice of the Consumer Survey [Press release]. https://www.pwc.com/gx/en/news-room/press-releases/2024/pwc-2024-voice-of-consumer-survey.html)

predictor, but price also having a strong influence (significant positive correlation) on whether consumers shift away from traditional luxury[35].

Because emerging and indie brands often offer more affordable prices than classic luxury labels — or at least lower barriers for first-time buyers — many buyers try these instead of waiting (or saving) for high-end luxury purchases. This means price sensitivity acts as a gateway for adoption of emerging brands. In short: more than exclusivity or brand legacy, many consumers now care about **value for money, price-to-quality balance, and affordability** — especially younger shoppers with limited budgets or many competing demands.Sustainability and ethical consumption appear to be another driving factor for the shift. Many younger consumers report that they care about environmental impact, ethical production, and transparent supply chains when buying fashion. A 2025 study examining consumer attitudes toward sustainable fashion found that social and environmental values significantly influence purchase intentions — especially among younger consumers.[36] Additionally, a large portion of Gen Z shoppers say they prefer sustainable brands: one recent survey found that 62% of Gen Z shoppers prefer to buy from sustainable brands, and 73% are willing to pay more for sustainable products compared to non-sustainable alternatives[37].

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[35] Mandarić, D., Hunjet, A., & Vuković, D. (2022). The impact of fashion brand sustainability on consumer purchasing decisions. Journal of Risk and Financial Management, 15(4), Article 176. https://doi.org/10.3390/jrfm15040176)

[36] Mandarić, D., Hunjet, A., & Vuković, D. (2022). The impact of fashion brand sustainability on consumer purchasing decisions. Journal of Risk and Financial Management, 15(4), Article 176. https://doi.org/10.3390/jrfm15040176)

[37] First Insight. (2019). The state of consumer spending: Gen Z shoppers demand sustainable retail [White paper]. https://www.firstinsight.com/white-papers-posts/gen-z-shoppers-demand-sustainability)

Because many established luxury brands are criticized for opaque supply chains, mass production, or high environmental costs, some consumers may distrust their “luxury equals quality” image. On the other hand, many emerging fashion brands — small, independent, digital-first — often build their identity around sustainability, ethical production, slow fashion, or even upcycling. This appeals to value-conscious and ethically-conscious consumers, encouraging them to shift from traditional luxury to emerging brands not just for price, but for values and ethics.

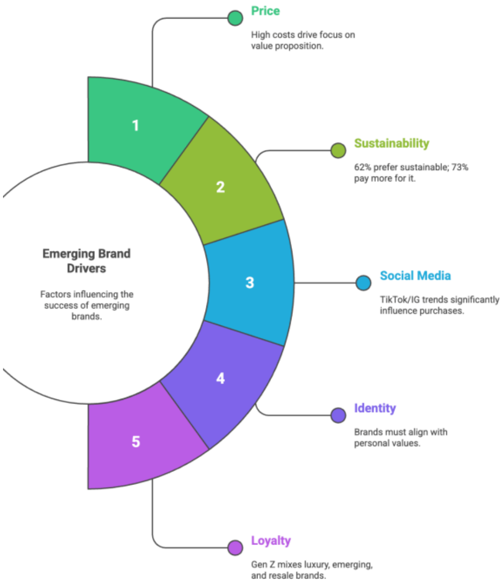

Figure 3 - Why Consumers Choose Emerging Brands

Digital media and social platforms play a powerful role in shaping modern fashion consumption and brand choice. According to a 2025 empirical study, content on platforms like TikTok and Instagram — whether brand-generated or user-generated — significantly influences young consumers' intention to buy sustainable or emerging fashion brands[38]. Moreover, the speed and reach of social media enable "micro-trends," viral styles, and rapid brand discovery. A recent computational study showed that social media sentiment patterns (positive or trending mentions) can predict rising fashion themes — especially for streetwear, sustainable fashion, and non-mainstream styles — before traditional trend forecasting catches up.Because emerging brands often rely heavily on social media, influencer collaborations, authenticity storytelling, and community-building — rather than huge advertising budgets — they can reach and influence younger consumers more directly. This digital-native advantage reduces the reliance on brand legacy or major retail infrastructure, making emerging brands more accessible and appealing to consumers who spend much time online.

Finally, identity expression emerges as a subtle but important driver. Many younger consumers today treat fashion not just as clothing, but as a form of **self-expression, personal identity, and social belonging**. Research shows that Gen Z and younger Millennials often look for brands that reflect their values, beliefs, lifestyle, or subculture — whether that is sustainability, gender-neutral clothing, street wear style, minimalism, or other niche aesthetics.[39] Emerging fashion brands often position themselves around such identity-driven values — e.g., sustainability, inclusivity, uniqueness — which makes them more attractive than traditional luxury houses that may feel exclusive, status-oriented, and generic in message. For instance, a growing number of younger buyers express interest in gender-

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[38] El-Shihy, D., & Awaad, S. (2025). Leveraging social media for sustainable fashion: How brand- and user-generated content influence Gen Z's purchase intentions. Fashion and Textiles, 11, Article 113. https://doi.org/10.1186/s43093-025-00529-3)

[39] Molenaar, K. (2024, October 1). 42 statistics for Gen Z spending power and habits in 2024. Influencer Marketing Hub. https://influencermarketinghub.com/gen-z-spending-habits-stats/

neutral clothing, eco-friendly materials, or small-batch production — all values that emerging labels are better able to deliver than big luxury firms[40].

Therefore, for many consumers especially those who value authenticity, social values, individuality emerging brands become not only a matter of price or convenience but also a form of identity alignment.

The shift from established luxury labels to emerging fashion brands is real and influenced by many different factors working together. It is not caused by just one reason. Instead, price sensitivity, sustainability concerns, digital influence, and identity expression all play an important role at the same time. Price sensitivity is often the starting point because many consumers, especially younger ones, face limited budgets or economic pressure, making emerging brands a more affordable and practical option. Sustainability and ethical concerns also encourage this shift, as emerging brands often present themselves as more responsible, environmentally friendly, and transparent, which creates a moral and emotional appeal. Digital influence, especially through social media platforms, increases the visibility of new brands and helps trends spread quickly, leading more people to try them. Finally, identity expression motivates consumers to choose brands that match their personal values, lifestyles, and social identity. Together, these factors explain why many consumers today are more open to emerging brands than ever before.This shift does not always mean abandonment of luxury forever. Many consumers seem to adopt a “hybrid wardrobe” approach: mixing luxury pieces with indie or emerging brands depending on mood, values, budget, and social context. But the trend suggests that emerging brands and more flexible,

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[40] Molenaar, K. (2024, October 1). 42 statistics for Gen Z spending power and habits in 2024. Influencer Marketing Hub. https://influencermarketinghub.com/gen-z-spending-habits-stats/)

value-driven consumption are becoming a significant and lasting force in the fashion world.Because of these combined drivers, traditional luxury houses — even though still powerful — risk losing influence among younger generations who demand more than prestige: they want price fairness, social responsibility, digital connection, and identity alignment.

Figure 4 - Luxury Market and Sustainability Trends

Discussion

The findings show that consumers, especially Gen Z and younger Millennials, are not completely abandoning established luxury labels, but they are clearly shifting part of their spending toward emerging fashion brands. This shift can be understood using classic and modern theories of consumption. Thorstein Veblen's idea of conspicuous consumption explains how people once bought luxury mainly to show wealth and status in public. In that model, high price itself was attractive, because it signalled exclusivity and social position.

Recent work on Veblen goods still shows that some luxury products behave this way: demand can rise when prices rise, because people want to stand out.

It also been observed that clothing is one way to pay respect towards their cultural roots, religion and community history. Thus the choice also depends on the way they feel about the brand .if the brand is respectfully and careful about the use of cultural symbols. Etc. Cultural mistakes done by brands are seriously punished in terms of sales ,revenue etc. and cause a big risk for their brand value .on the other hand younger generation reward brands that share their cultural backgrounds social values and community stories . Thus we can say that they choose what belongs to them and their culture over exclusivity.

Many younger shoppers no longer follow the old rule that “the most expensive item shows the most status.” Instead, many Gen Z consumers live with tight budgets and think carefully before spending. They often buy good “dupes,” second-hand pieces, or cheaper alternatives and feel proud of finding a smart deal, not embarrassed by it. For them, status is not only about money. It is also about being smart, kind to the planet, and aware of culture. In this context, people use brands to say something about who they are – their values, daily life, and personality. When they choose slow-fashion or sustainable clothes, they often feel they are doing the right thing, which adds an emotional reward to the purchase..Slow fashion studies also find that buying sustainable clothing can make consumers feel they are “good” or responsible people, adding a strong emotional and symbolic layer to the purchase[41].

The findings from your literature and data suggest that digital influence and identity expression are especially powerful drivers, with price sensitivity and sustainability close behind. Social media platforms like TikTok and Instagram have become key spaces where

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[41] Castagna, A. C., Pencarelli, T., & Forlani, F. (2022). Slow fashion or self-signaling? Sustainability in the fashion industry. Journal of Cleaner Production, 363, 132608. https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S235255092200077X)

trends are made and where emerging brands can build strong emotional stories, sometimes faster than traditional luxury houses[42]. At the same time, surveys show that a majority of Gen Z prefer to buy from sustainable brands and are willing to pay somewhat more for ethical products, as long as prices stay reasonable[43].This suggests that no single factor works alone: young consumers are price-aware, but they also care about values and meaning. When an emerging brand offers good design, fair price, strong digital presence, and identity fit, it becomes a serious alternative to established luxury, even if the logo is less famous.

These findings are broadly in line with recent academic and industry literature. McKinsey's *State of Fashion* reports describe a luxury sector where growth is slowing and younger consumers demand more authenticity, emotional connection, and digital interaction, not just heritage and status[44]. Highsnobiety's "new luxury" work also argues that cultural relevance, community, and storytelling now matter as much as traditional markers of luxury such as price, scarcity, and brand age.[45]

The strong role of **sustainability and identity** also agrees with studies that link sustainable fashion to self-signalling: people buy ethical clothing partly to express their moral

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[42] Petrarca, E. (2024, December 18). Brat, bodysuits and bag charms: The year in TikTok. Vogue. https://www.vogue.com/article/brat-bodysuits-and-bag-charms-the-year-in-tiktok)

[43] First Insight. (2019). *The state of consumer spending: Gen Z shoppers demand sustainable retail* [White paper]. https://www.firstinsight.com/white-papers-posts/gen-z-shoppers-demand-sustainability)

[44] McKinsey & Company. (2023). The State of Fashion 2023. https://www.mckinsey.com/industries/retail/our-insights/state-of-fashion

[45] Stagg, N. (2025). Luxury redefined: Stop selling the dream. Start fitting into reality [White paper]. Highsnobiety. https://www.highsnobiety.com/p/luxury-redefined-white-paper-2025/)

identity and feel consistent with their values.[46]The high percentage of Gen Z who prefer sustainable brands and are willing to pay more supports this view.[47] However Some luxury items, like watches and handbags, still work as status symbols, and many consumers still aspire to own the prestige of a big brand name. the way status was defines is now changing , people are becoming more creative sustainable and culturally aware and inclusive rather than just showing wealth . in this way this study also suggest that status does not exist and will not exist but it indicates that form of presenting the status will evolve and change with news brands. These patterns rekey for both news and established brands that relying only on high prices, logos, and heritage is no longer enough. McKinsey's 2025 luxury outlook notes that growth is slowing and that now is the time for "bold risks" and renewed connection with clients.[48] Luxury brands need deeper **digital transformation** creating genuine, honest and engaging communication on social media, and develop communities. They need to adapt to more flexible ways for consumers to experience the brand, including resale, rental, and limited but accessible products. They also need to make their sustainability actions real and transparent, not just marketing claims, because younger consumers actively question greenwashing and can quickly share doubts online[49].

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[46] Castagna, A. C., Pencarelli, T., & Forlani, F. (2022). Slow fashion or self-signaling? Sustainability in the fashion industry. Journal of Cleaner Production, 363, 132608. https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S235255092200077X)

[47] First Insight. (2019). The state of consumer spending: Gen Z shoppers demand sustainable retail [White paper]. https://www.firstinsight.com/white-papers-posts/gen-z-shoppers-demand-sustainability)

[48] McKinsey & Company. (2025, January 13). The state of luxury: How to navigate a slowdown. https://www.mckinsey.com/industries/retail/our-insights/state-of-luxury

[49] Logan, G., Hoang, H. A., Sadeghzadeh, K., & Sanz, P. (2025). The alchemy of luxury: Where Gen Z fuses sustainability, storytelling, and self-image. Kantar. https://www.kantar.com/north-america/inspiration/sustainability/the-alchemy-of-luxury-where-gen-z-fuses-sustainability-storytelling-and-self-image)

As global market offers large opportunities to **emerging brands**, the findings suggest that opportunities are linked to responsibilities too. They are able to reach out to maximum number of potential consumers and able to motivate them to buy their product because of combination of factors such as fairer prices, strong online storytelling, and clear value positions (such as sustainability, inclusivity, or niche aesthetics). Brands who will be able to maintain product quality and stay honest about their ethics, and continue to build genuine communities will stay in the market for longer period of time on the other hand Brands who chase hype, the short term growth trend will be eliminated and die very soon.[50] researchers and policymakers, see that new pattern in these results the domain of fashion consumption is a useful way to understand broader social change. The change from conspicuous consumption to more "affordable luxury" and mix of **alues, and visibility** shows how younger generations are trying to balance enjoyment, ethics, and economics in practical manner. Future research could test more precisely which factor — price, sustainability, digital influence, or identity expression has the strongest effect in different regions and income groups, and how this balance shifts over time as the luxury sector and wider economy continue to evolve.

Conclusion

Gen Z and younger Millennials as consumers have not left or completely shifted from traditional luxury brand labels but part of their spending is going to new and emerging brands. They are willing to experiment newer style and adapting with changing order and time in fashion industry. New brands founded by innovative founders are reaching and

[50] .(Highsnobiety. (2021). The NEXT 20: Who will shape youth culture in 2021? https://www.highsnobiety.com/p/the-next-20-report-q1-2021/)

attracting global audience with the use of strong digital marketing and use of social media. The data clearly shows that shifting and part of their spending from established luxury labels to emerging fashion brands. This means Younger consumers no longer focus only on traditional luxury markers like logo, heritage, and exclusivity. Instead, they look for brands that offer a mix of fair pricing “affordable luxury”, authentic sustainability, strong digital presence, and identity expression. Among these factors, digital influence and identity expression appear to be the strongest drivers, because social media and online communities play a huge role in shaping trends and raising the awareness about ethical and transparent supply chain, climate push. Affordability is also important as rising inflation and higher luxury prices push people to look for better value. Climate matters too, especially for those who want clothing that reflects their ethical beliefs. Together, these factors explain why new brands now attract more attention and loyalty than before. The shift is taking place very fast among individuals who are price-conscious, value ethical production, are influenced by online content, and want brands that match their personal identity. While establish age old luxury brands are still very powerful in terms of revenue , market share and popularity , they no longer dominate consumer loyalty the way they used to do a decade ago[51]. Therefore we can say that research and data supports the hypothesis that the transition toward emerging brands is **real, growing, and driven by a combination of economic, cultural, and digital factors**, with identity and digital influence playing the biggest roles. Future research could be to study the different level of shift different across countries, consumer segment and cultural groups. It would also be key area to explore long-term loyalty patterns among these emerging brands, and to examine the role of resale markets. What will be the future strategy for their

[51] Andreeva, S. (2024, December 5). How Gen Z purchasing behavior is shaping clothing retail? BrandsGateway. https://brandsgateway.com/blog/gen-z-purchasing-behavior/)

growth ?, how emerging brands can maintain growth as they scale. Deeper segmentation studies will offer clearer insights for both industry and researchers[52].

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